

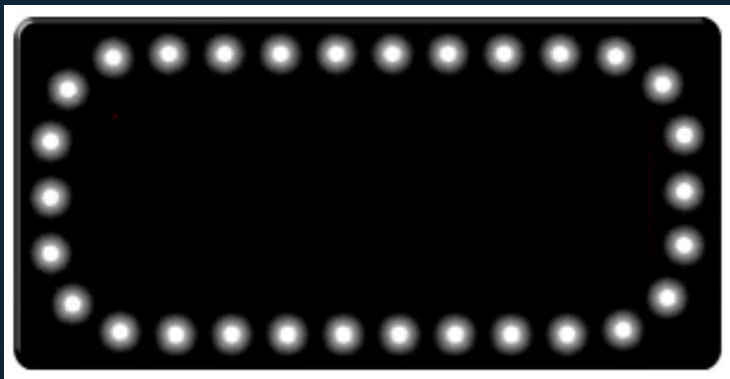
Class 9: Politically Violent Activity

Escalation and restraint

AUTHOR

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Opening notes



Presentation groups

December

January

Presentations line-up

Date	Presenters	Method
4 Dec:		TBD
11 Dec:		TBD
18 Dec:		TBD

- opening discussion
- debatable proposition and pressing policy issue
- antifa in Germany
- Copsey and Merrill (2020): antifa in the U.S.



Opening discussion

What should we, students of political violence, know about *antifa*? (causes? organisation/leadership? radical subcultures and mobilisation? strategies?)

...

is antifa a 'gang' (Pyrooz and Densley 2018)? is antifa a 'group' (LaFree 2018)?

- **gang** - 'durable and street-oriented youth group whose involvement in illegal activity is part of its group identity' (Pyrooz and Densley 2018, 230)
- **group** - 'some stable organisation that persists over time and has some discernible leadership structure' (LaFree 2018, 249), see also GTF database: <https://www.start.umd.edu/gtd/>

Debatable proposition: antifa as terrorist org.?

Pyrooz and Densley (2018, 233): “the history of antifa reads like a history of violence”

VS.

Bray (2017, 169): “In truth, violence represents a small though vital sliver of anti-fascist activity.”

...

Should state security (in Germany, elsewhere) designate antifa as *extremist/terrorist*

antifa (recently) in Germany

ARD series (in German): <https://www.ardaudiothek.de/sendung/die-fascho-jaegerin-der-fall-lina-e-und-seine-folgen/94838298/>

- 28-year-old antifa activist, Lina E., and three accomplices jailed for either membership of or support for a criminal organisation.
 - politicised/radicalised by revelations about NSU in 2011
- attacks on (assumed) right-wing extremists in Thüringen and Sachsen between 2018 and 2020
- judge...
 - acknowledged deficiency of criminal punishment of neo-Nazis
 - described right-wing extremism as a greater threat to Germany
 - but asserted 'even Nazis have inalienable rights'
 - criticized the defense lawyers for describing the trial as "political justice."

recent journal article: Jones and Schuhmacher (2024)

Copsey and Merrill (2020) - background

- Since 2001, **right-wing extremists** in the U.S. responsible for **110 politically motivated deaths** — antifa: 0 (or maximum one, in case of 2020 death of Patriot Prayer supporter)

In putting their "bodies on the line," militant anti-fascists aspire to defeat fascist organizing, to destabilize it, and ultimately de-mobilize it. At its root, anti-fascist militancy is the promise to effect intimidation, humiliation and de-moralization upon fascists. This involves a physical commitment to "no platforming" (p. 124)

- lots of informative background information about U.S. antifa in the article

Copsey and Merrill (2020) - research design

- **semi-structured interviews** with activists from RCA in Portland
 - conditions of anonymity
 - between **October 2019** and **February 2020**.
- sample of 3971 tweets (including 2484 retweets) shared by RCA's Twitter account (@RoseCityAntifa)
 - between **13 March 2018** and **28 August 2019**
 - collected using *Tweeepy* in accordance with Twitter's regulations
 - 'more militant' tweets—"648 tweets (including 279 retweets) from within this sample which featured variants of "violence," "attack," "assault," "fight," and "terror""
 - close reading; quantitatively and qualitatively analysed with **critical discourse analysis** approach

Copsey and Merrill (2020) - findings/points raised

- violent disruption of "fascist" assembly is an axiom of antifa praxis
- how far does the label 'fascist' extend?

- “*legitimacy of anti-fascist action is thus drawn from the illegitimacy of its opponent*”
- antifa’s “*pre-emptive self-defence*”
 - premised on (a) deadliness of fascist movements of any size and (b) rapid growth potential of fascist movements
- there are ‘*internal tactical*’ and rhetorical *strategies* that *limit* violence’ from antifa — BUT, consistent danger of antifa slipping into glorification of violence

Poll: escalation and restraint



Take the survey at <https://forms.gle/12tV7fgjcAyC8iVG6>

- ideology secondary to pragmatic issues in choosing to use violence?
 - most important in allowing *restraint*?
 - most likely to provoke *escalation*?
-
- should states remain open to negotiating with violent groups?
 - groups more likely to escalate violence if they feel they are losing support?

```
md`## Poll results (Respondents: ${respondentCount})`
```

Poll results (Respondents: 2)

```
import { liveGoogleSheet } from "@jimjamslam/live-google-sheet";
import { aq, op } from "@uwdata/arquero";

// UPDATE THE LINK FOR A NEW POLL
surveyResults = liveGoogleSheet(
  "https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/e/" +
    "2PACX-1vSzXDDMtCvL7AeQx2C5Qwg_FEhFHA6dWov5vprYGiQLzzFJARc0RJQniUe-InSkwTCCqTdTv_XXKe" +
    "pub?gid=720467942&single=true&output=csv",
  10000, 1, 6); // adjust the last number to select all relevant columns

respondentCount = surveyResults.length;
```

ideology secondary to pragmatic issues?

more likely to escalate if losing support?

```
ideology_secondCounts = aq.from(surveyResult
  .select("ideology_second")
  .groupby("ideology_second")
  .count()
  .derive({ measure: d => "" }))
```

```
// Calculate the maximum count from your data
ideology_second_maxCountRE = Math.max(...ide
```

```

plot_ideology_second = Plot.plot({
  marks: [
    Plot.baryY(ideology_secondCounts, {
      x: "ideology_second",
      y: "count",
      fill: "ideology_second",
      stroke: "black",
      strokeWidth: 1
    }),
    Plot.ruleY([respondentCount], { stroke:
  ],
  color: {
    domain: [
      "Strongly disagree",
      "Disagree",
      "Neutral",
      "Agree",
      "Strongly agree"
    ],
    range: [
      "red",
      "pink",
      "lightgrey",
      "lightgreen",
      "forestgreen"
    ]
  },
  marginBottom: 180,
  x: { label: "", tickSize: 2, tickRotate: -
    domain: ["Strongly disagree", "Disagree"
  },
  y: {
    label: "",
    tickSize: 10,
    tickFormat: d => d,
    tickValues: Array.from(
      new Set(ideology_secondCounts.objects(
    ).sort((a, b) => a - b),
    domain: [0, ideology_second_maxCountRE
  },

```

```
losing_supportCounts = aq.from(surveyResults
  .select("losing_support")
  .groupby("losing_support")
  .count()
  .derive({ measure: d => "" })
```

```
// Calculate the maximum count from your data
losing_support_maxCountRE = Math.max(...losing_support_maxCountRE)
```

```

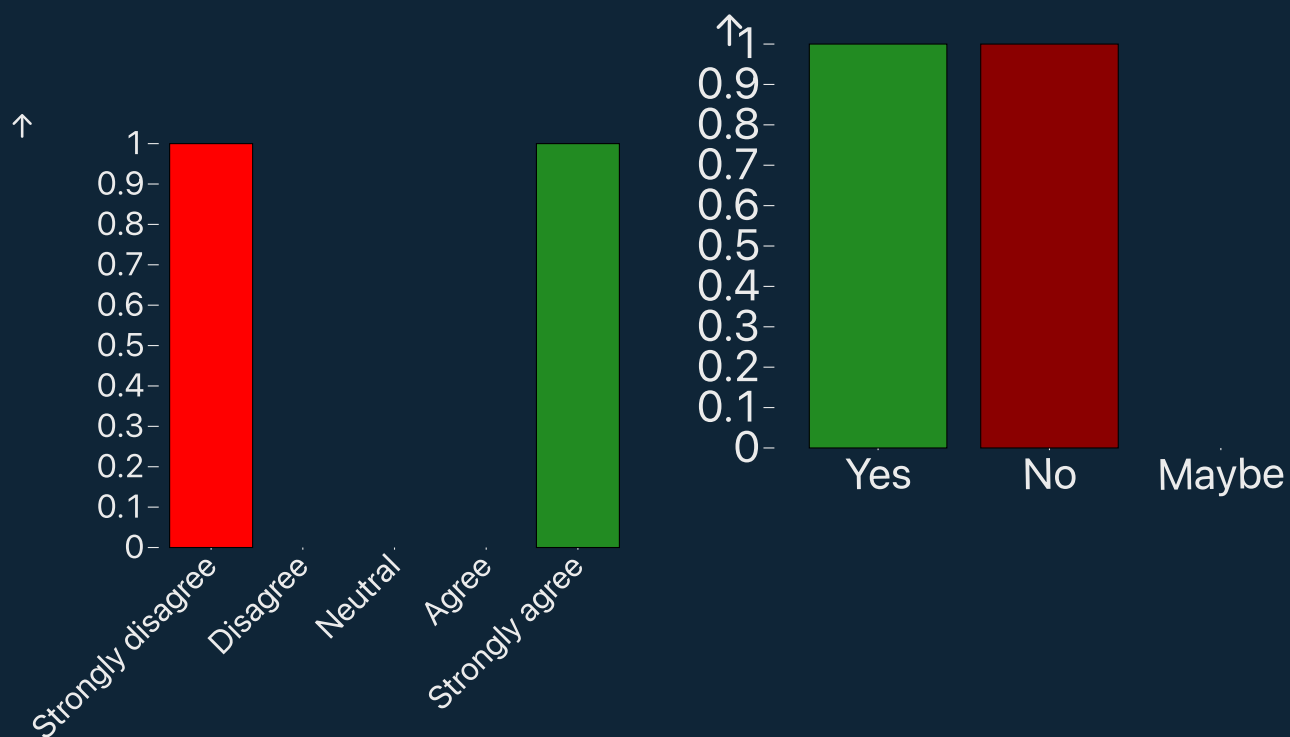
plot_losing_support = Plot.plot({
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    }),
    Plot.ruleY([respondentCount], { stroke:
  ],
  color: {
    domain: [
      "Yes",
      "No",
      "Maybe"
    ],
    range: [
      "forestgreen",
      "darkred",
      "goldenrod"
    ]
  },
  marginBottom: 80,
  x: { label: "", tickSize: 2, tickRotate: -
    domain: ["Yes", "No", "Maybe"]
  },
  y: {
    label: "",
    tickSize: 10,
    tickFormat: d => d,
    tickValues: Array.from(
      new Set(losing_supportCounts.objects()
    ).sort((a, b) => a - b),
    domain: [0, losing_support_maxCountRE]
  },
  facet: { data: losing_supportCounts, x: "m
  marginLeft: 60,
  style: {
    width: 1600.

```

Poll results: escalation and restraint

```
    facet: { data: ideology_secondCounts, x: "
marginLeft: 140,
style: {
  width: 1350,
  height: 500,
  fontSize: 30,
}
});

width: 1800,
height: 500,
fontSize: 40,
},
});
```



most important factor allowing *restraint*?

```
allows_restraintCounts = aq.from(surveyResul
  .select("allows_restraint")
  .groupby("allows_restraint")
  .count()
  .derive({ measure: d => "" }})
```

```
// Calculate the maximum count from your dat
allows_restraint_maxCountRE = Math.max(...al
```

```
plot_allows_restraint = Plot.plot({
  marks: [
    Plot.barY(allows_restraintCounts, {
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      y: "count",
      fill: "allows_restraint",
      stroke: "black",
      strokeWidth: 1
    }),
    Plot.ruleY([respondentCount], { stroke:
  ],
  color: {
    domain: [
      "strategic factors",
      "resource constraints",
      "moral convictions",
      "strong/weak organisation",
      "other"
    ],
    range: [
      "darkred",
      "goldenrod",
      "cadetblue",
      "forestgreen",
      "gray"
    ]
  },
  marginBottom: 400,
  x: { label: "", tickSize: 2, tickRotate: -
    domain: ["strategic factors", "resource
  },
  y: {
    label: "",
    tickSize: 10,
    tickFormat: d => d,
    tickValues: Array.from(
      new Set(allows_restraintCounts.objects
    ).sort((a, b) => a - b),
    domain: [0, allows_restraint_maxCountRE]
  },
  facet: { data: allows_restraintCounts, x
  marginLeft: 60,
```

most likely to provoke *escalation*?

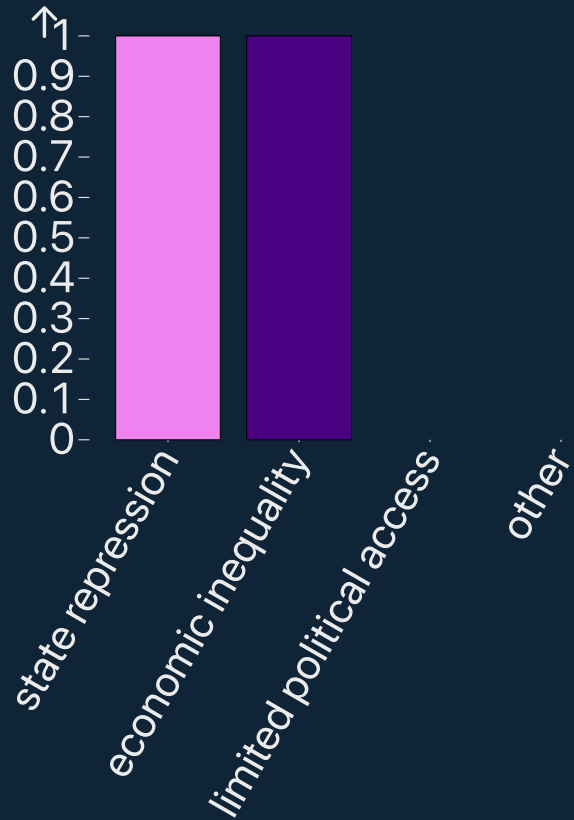
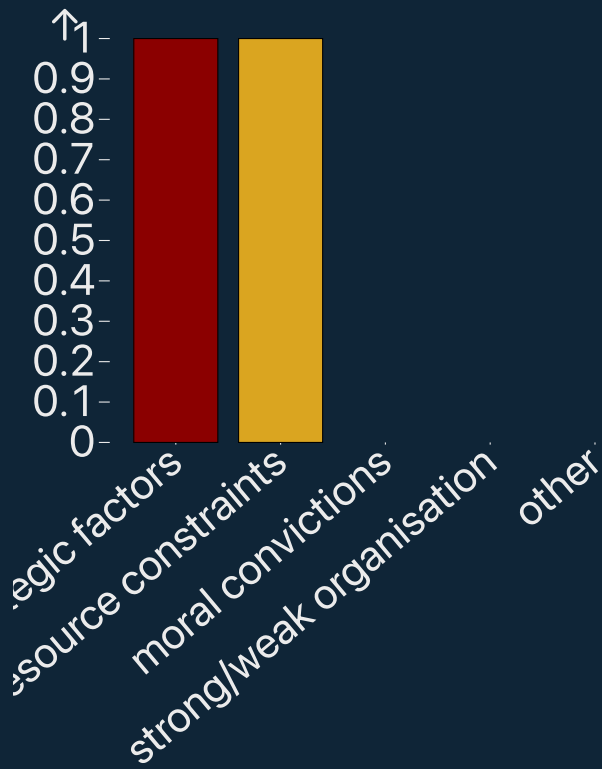
```
provoke_escalationCounts = aq.from(surveyRes
  .select("provoke_escalation")
  .groupby("provoke_escalation")
  .count()
  .derive({ measure: d => "" }})
```

```
// Calculate the maximum count from your dat
provoke_escalation_maxCountRE = Math.max(...
```

```
plot_provoke_escalation = Plot.plot({
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    Plot.barY(provoke_escalationCounts, {
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      y: "count",
      fill: "provoke_escalation",
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      strokeWidth: 1
    }),
    Plot.ruleY([respondentCount], { stroke:
  ],
  color: {
    domain: [
      "state repression",
      "economic inequality",
      "limited political access",
      "other"
    ],
    range: [
      "violet",
      "indigo",
      "goldenrod",
      "orange"
    ]
  },
  marginBottom: 500,
  x: { label: "", tickSize: 2, tickRotate: -
    domain: ["state repression", "economic i
  },
  y: {
    label: "",
    tickSize: 10,
    tickFormat: d => d,
    tickValues: Array.from(
      new Set(provoke_escalationCounts.objec
    ).sort((a, b) => a - b),
    domain: [0, provoke_escalation_maxCountR
  },
  facet: { data: provoke_escalationCounts, x
  marginLeft: 60,
```


Poll results: negotiation

states should remain open to negotiating with politically violent groups?



```

negotiatingCounts = aq.from(surveyResults)
  .select("negotiating")
  .groupby("negotiating")
  .count()
  .derive({ measure: d => "" })

// Calculate the maximum count from your data
negotiating_maxCountRE = Math.max(...negotiatingCounts.map(d => d.count))

plot_negotiating = Plot.plot({
  marks: [
    Plot.barY(negotiatingCounts, {
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      y: "count",
      fill: "negotiating",
      stroke: "black",
      strokeWidth: 1
    }),
    Plot.ruleY([respondentCount], { stroke: "black" })
  ],
  color: {
    domain: [
      "Strongly disagree",
      "Disagree",
      "Neutral",
      "Agree",
      "Strongly agree"
    ],
    range: [
      "red",
      "pink",
      "lightgrey",
      "lightgreen",
      "forestgreen"
    ]
  },
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    domain: ["Strongly disagree", "Disagree", "Neutral", "Agree", "Strongly agree"]
  },
  y: {
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    tickSize: 10,
    tickFormat: d => d,
    tickValues: Array.from(
      new Set(negotiatingCounts.objects().map(d => d.count))
    ).sort((a, b) => a - b),
    domain: [0, negotiating_maxCountRE]
  },
  facet: { data: negotiatingCounts, x: "measure" }
})

```

Mechanisms of escalation and restraint

- escalation and restraint concepts
- catalogue of mechanisms
- grouped/summarised mechanisms
 - restraint
 - escalation



↑ escalation and restraint

- **escalation** - a rise in the frequency and/or severity of violent actions
- **restraint** - a deliberate restriction (either reducing or completely stopping) of violent actions

... are there any significant examples of escalation and/or restraint in cases you know of?

Mechanisms of escalation and restraint

relational arena	Violence-enabling mechanisms	Violence-inhibiting mechanisms
Within movement arena	A1.1. Intensification of threat narrative A1.2. Foregrounding of revolutionary goals A1.3. Declining influence of moderates A1.4. Valorisation of violence A1.5. Ident. violence as a viable or necessary strategy A1.6. Fear of missing out A1.7. Preparation for violence	B1.1. Campaign/issue deprioritisation or closure B1.2. Foregrounding non-revolutionary goals B1.3. Persistent or expanding influence of moderates B1.4. Disassociation from violence and/or ident. violence as counter-productive B1.5. Rules limiting the use of or opportunities for violence B1.6. Within-movement backlash against violence
movement-opposition arena	A2.1. Increasingly hostile emotional entrainment between activists and their opponents A2.2. Increased mutual expectation of violence A2.3. Increased availability of 'legitimate' targets A2.4. Sudden power imbalance between opposing groups	B2.1. Tactical and/or emotional disentrainment B2.2. Limited expectations of violence B2.3. Steady balance of power within situational contexts B2.4. Achievement of dominance without need for (further) violence
movement-political environment arena	A3.1. Diminishing political opportunities A3.2. Growing ident. of 'corrupt elites' as 'the enemy' A3.3. Radical flank actors become the focus of political and/or media attention A3.4. Elites endorse polarising issue frame A3.5. Elites Legitimate violence	B3.1. Ways to pursue goals through less extreme means B3.2. Alliance of movement and political or cultural elites B3.3. Elite allies withdraw support in response to rising use or threats of violence by movement actors
movement-security forces arena	A4.1. Comm. breakdown between activists and security A4.2. Loss of control by state security actors	B4.1. Open communication between security and activists B4.2. Security forces maintain control (without breaching societal norms of appropriate policing)
movement-public arena	A5.1. Decoupling of movement from general public A5.2. (Part of) public endorse of polarising issue frame A5.3. Legitimation of violence by members of the public	B5.1. Activists emphasise import of broad public support B5.2. Key constituencies criticise 'inappropriate' violence

summarising logics of restraint - (Busher et al. 2022; Bjørge and Ravndal 2020)

(‘ascending the ladder of abstraction,’ Sartori 1970)

1. A **strategic logic** (violence is counterproductive in the present circumstances)
2. A **moral logic** (certain forms of violence are illegitimate)
3. A **logic of ego maintenance** (we are not a violent organization)
4. A **logic of outgroup definition** (softening views on putative outgroups)
5. An **organisational logic** (the organisation evolves in ways that undermine the logics of violent escalation)

summarising logics of escalation - Busher et al. (2022)

(‘ascending the ladder of abstraction,’ Sartori 1970)

1. **framing logic** (intensity of context/threat, revolutionary goals, glorification of violence, violence as viable/necessary, increasing vilification of ‘enemies’)
2. **strategic logic** (cope with changing dynamics with opponents and/or state, deal with diminishing opportunity, loss of state control)
3. **organisational logic** (declining moderate influence, logistical/practical preparation for violence)
4. **constituency/social logic** (endorsement/legitimation from elites and/or public, politics/media focuses on radical flank)

A case of RWE restraint?

- Nordic Resistance Movement (NRM) at a glance
- Tore Bjørge on NRM
 - findings



NRM at a glance

- Territory of action: Scandinavia [Blomberg and Stier (2019);]
- Organisational structure: hierarchical national branches
- Membership: moderate (varies by country, e.g., [Stiftelsen Expo 2025](#))
- (main) Objective: white ethno-state
- (common) Targets: political and ethnic opponents



- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence, connected to terrorism (e.g., Finland, [Ravndal 2020](#); [Kotonen 2021](#); [Zeller and Vaughan 2024](#))

Nordic Resistance Movement (NRM) - Tore Bjørgo

Tore Bjørgo on Why the Nordic Resistance Movement Restrains its Use of Violence ([Bjørgo and Ravndal 2020](#))



Nordic Resistance Movement (NRM) - Tore Bjørgo

1. *When, why does NRM permit use of violence?*
 - no **moral restraints**, rather **violence perceived as counter-productive** (to gaining support and freely propagating views)
 - try to **expand boundaries of acceptable violence** with acts against police and political enemies
2. *Why, how does NRM restrain use of violence?*
 - to maintain **strategic position**
 - commit members to **maintaining nonviolent discipline**
3. *How does NRM leadership respond to cases where members overstep and act violently?*
 - **honouring** rather than **punishing** activists who overstep
 - BUT ALSO **distancing** from any affiliation or connection

Any questions, concerns, feedback for this class?

Anonymous feedback here: <https://forms.gle/NfF1pCfYMBkAT3WP6>

Alternatively, please send me an email: m.zeller@lmu.de

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